

My Honest Assessment: Yes, Restructure. Here's Why.

Your current structure has one fundamental architectural flaw that can't be patched — the same knowledge domains are split across two separate top-level sections for no user-facing reason. Look at what you have right now:

Intelligence Section	Analyze & Tools Section
Policy pillar	Policy & Quality Sciences Lab
Technology pillar	Technology & AI Lab
Equity pillar	Population & Equity Lab
Economics pillar	Payment Models & VBC Lab
Clinical pillar	Interoperability & Risk Lab

A user interested in policy has content they need in two completely different sections of the sidebar. That's not a tab problem. That's not a naming problem. That's a structural split of the same domain across two buckets — and users feel it as disorganization even if they can't articulate why. The current model organizes around mode (learn / analyze / read). World-class platforms organize around domain (what the user actually thinks in).

The Right Architecture: Domain-First

Bloomberg doesn't put "read about equities" in one section and "analyze equities" in another. Everything about equities is in equities. That's the model. Your Intelligence Pillars are already your strongest organizing concept — they're the knowledge domains your users actually operate in. Everything else should flow into and out of them.

Proposed Top-Level Structure

PRIMARY NAV — The Domain Hubs

- POLICY → Intelligence + Policy Lab + Policy learning
- ECONOMICS → Intelligence + Payment Models Lab + Finance learning
- TECHNOLOGY → Intelligence + Tech & AI Lab + Tech learning
- CLINICAL → Intelligence + Interoperability + Risk Lab + Clinical learning
- EQUITY → Intelligence + Population & Equity Lab + Equity learning
- OPERATIONS → Intelligence + Ops tools + Ops learning
- STATES → Vermont, California, 50-State Dashboard, AHEAD

SECONDARY NAV — Cross-Domain Utilities

- TOOLS → HTR Simulator, Medicaid Eligibility, Investment Tracker, HTI Dashboard, The Wire, Friction Index, Impact Simulation
- ACADEMY → Learning Tracks, Certifications, Webinars, Faculty, Glossary (structured curricula only — not domain-specific content)
- ADVISORY → Consulting, Research, Financial Audit, Regulatory, Community

Under each Domain Hub, contextual sub-navigation:

POLICY (example)

- Intelligence → curated articles, analyses, reports
- Research Lab → Policy Simulator, Clinical Quality Optimizer, HTA Studio, Actuarial Lab, Hospital Financial Scorecard
- Learning → policy-specific courses, case studies, webinars
- Advisory → regulatory counsel, policy consulting

What This Solves

Problem	Current	Restructured
Domain split across sections	Policy content in 2 places	One policy hub, everything inside
"Interoperability + Risk" mismatch	Forced onto same page	Clinical hub with separate sub-tools
"Analyze & Tools" as a dumping ground	15 items, mixed purposes	Domain hubs absorb the labs; utilities move to Tools
User has to know which section to search	5 sections with different logic	Think in domain, go to that domain
Navigation principle inconsistency	Action + Content + Geography + Business	Domain + Utility (two clear tiers)

What This Costs (Honestly)

This is real work. Not a rewrite of the UI — the components, labs, and pages are all fine. But:

- HomeSidebar — complete restructure (the largest single piece of work)
- URLs — all /research-lab/* routes move into their domain (need redirects)
- Research Lab hub page — becomes domain landing pages; the central hub becomes less necessary
- PillarSidebar — can be promoted to the main nav
- Academy — slims down to structured learning only; domain-specific content moves to domain hubs
- "Analyze & Tools" section — dissolved; labs absorbed into domains, standalone tools get their own section

Estimate: this is a 1–2 week focused effort if done cleanly. It is not a months-long rebuild.

Recommendation

Do the restructure. The domain-first model is the right architecture for a platform of this ambition. Every world-class knowledge platform — Bloomberg, McKinsey, NEJM — organizes this way. The current structure will keep generating "disorganization" feedback because the structure is disorganized at a fundamental level. Patching the Research Labs buys time; it doesn't fix the root cause.

The good news: your content is strong, your components work, and the Intelligence Pillar system is already the right mental model. You're mostly reorganizing the container, not rebuilding the content. Want me to start with a detailed implementation plan for the HomeSidebar restructure?